

Develop Solutions & Ideate · Winnie Nguyen —

A PRACTICAL UX SKILL

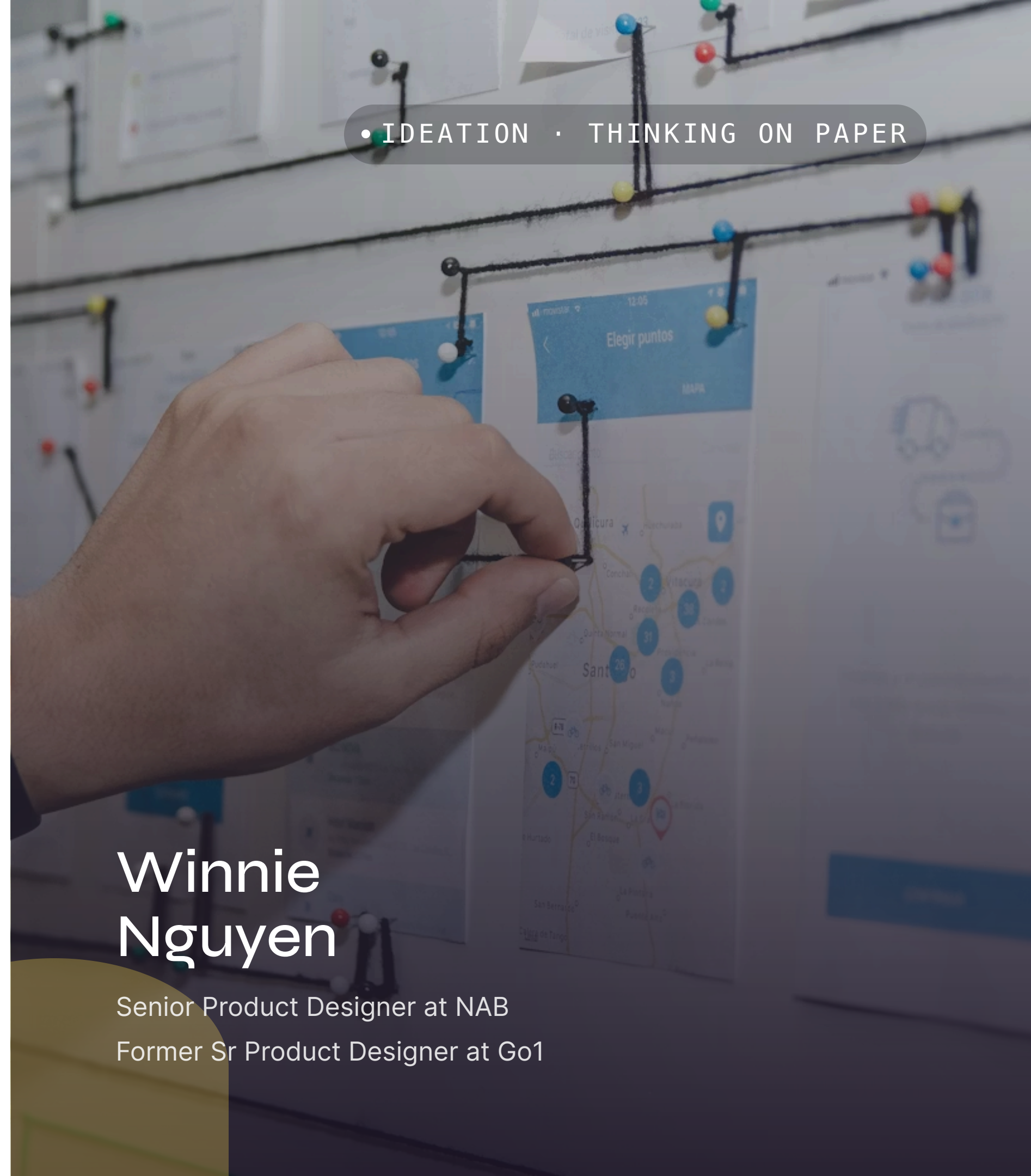
Concept Sketching

Make the most promising ideas visible enough to evaluate, discuss, and develop further.

• IDEATION · THINKING ON PAPER

Winnie
Nguyen

Senior Product Designer at NAB
Former Sr Product Designer at Go1



WHY WE SKETCH CONCEPTS

**Make the best ideas visible,
legible, and discussable — before
you build them.**

You've gone wide on solutions. Now you need a way to take the most promising ones and put them in front of people — rough enough to change, clear enough to judge.

— THE DEFINITION

A single rough illustration of one idea

It shows what the solution is, how it's structured, and what makes it different from the obvious approach.

~~A wireframe~~ · A thinking tool

— WHAT A FINISHED SKETCH LOOKS LIKE

Four parts — readable by someone cold in under 30 seconds

01 Key screen or moment

The one to three views that make the concept legible — the discovery screen, the decision moment.

03 Intent annotations

Short notes on why things are placed where they are — "below the fold so the user commits to browsing first".

02 Component labels

Named parts of the UI or interaction — "filter by distance", "seasonal tag", "pack contents".

04 One-sentence rationale

"This works because..." — the logic that holds the whole concept together.

What two labelled concept sketches look like

A

Browse what's fresh now

On-demand · react to today's stock

Fresh today

1

In season this week

2

Tomatoes — picked today

Add to basket

1

Seasonal banner

INTENT

 make freshness the first thing seen

PLACE

 pinned to the top, above the fold

2

Freshness tag

INTENT

 prove it's fresh at the point of choice

PLACE

 on each product card

“

This works because it surfaces freshness at the moment of decision.

B

Weekly seasonal pack

Plan ahead · curated subscription

Your weekly pack

1

6 seasonal items this week

2

Deliver every Thursday

Confirm pack

1

Pack preview

INTENT

 show the whole pack's value upfront

PLACE

 hero position, top of screen

2

Delivery day

INTENT

 turn buying into a repeatable habit

PLACE

 one tap, directly below the pack

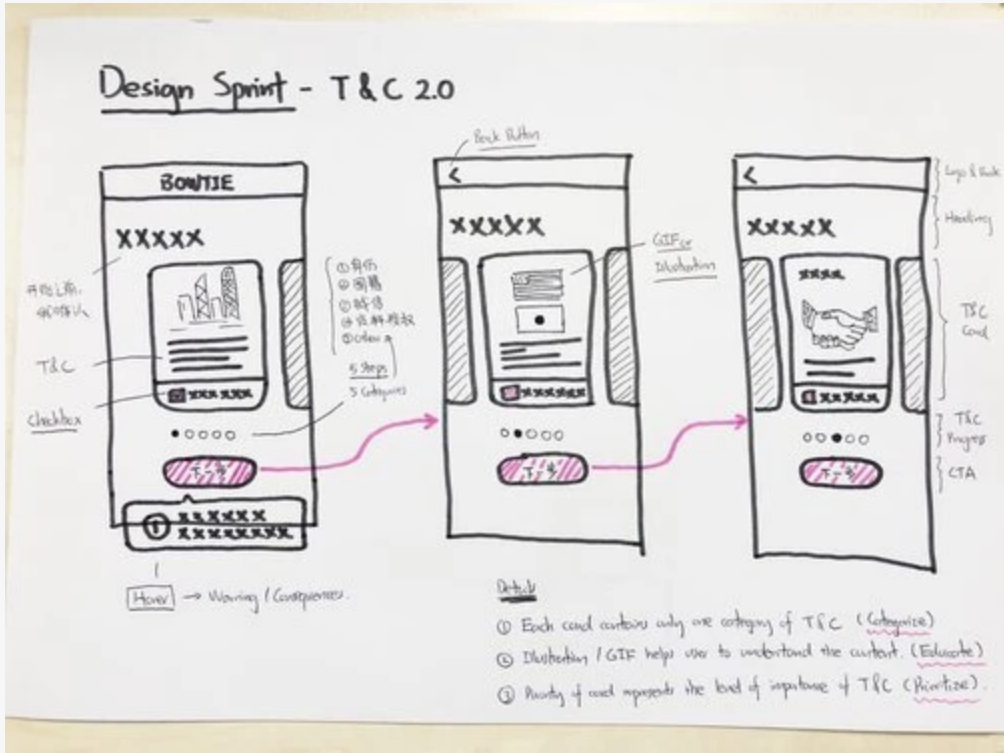
“

This works because it removes the daily decision and builds a habit.

— REAL CONCEPT SKETCHES · THE SAME ANATOMY, BY HAND

What they look like in the wild

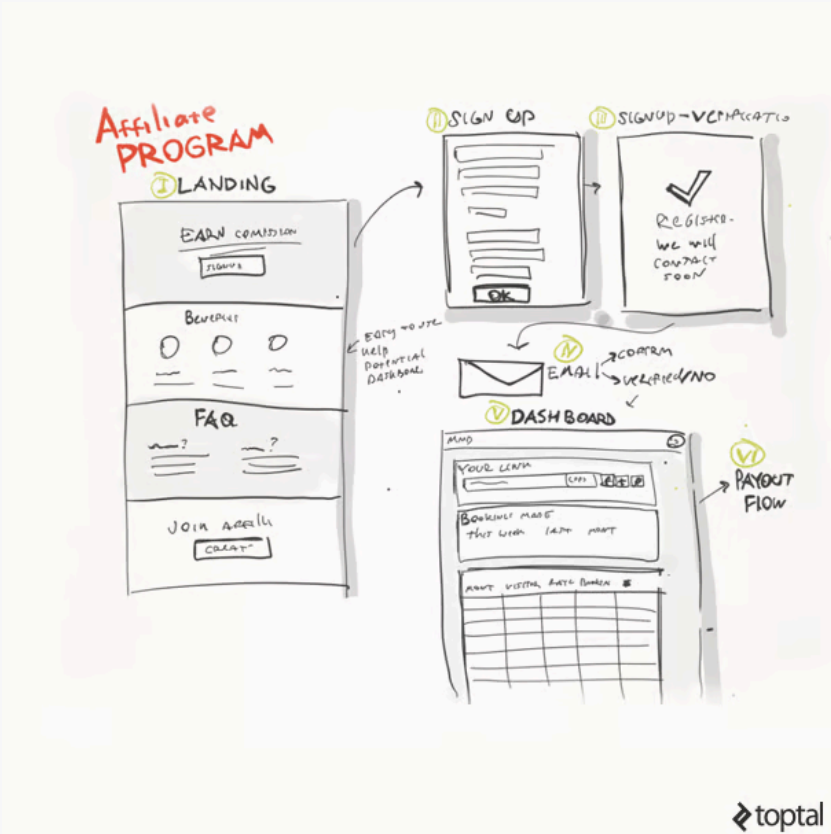
Different products, same moves — a few key screens, components labelled, and intent and priority noted by hand. Rough, but completely readable.



Bowtie — T&C 2.0, design sprint

Three key screens, each card labelled and annotated with its intent: categorise · educate · prioritise.

DANNY C.K.M · 5-DAY GOOGLE DESIGN SPRINT



Affiliate program — the full flow

Six numbered screens trace the journey: landing → sign-up → email → dashboard → payout.

TOPTAL · GUIDE TO UX SKETCHING

How to sketch a concept — six moves

01 Identify your starting point

A HMW question, a research insight, an analogy, a constraint, or a Crazy 8s panel.

02 Find the one moment

The key screen, decision point, or interaction that makes the concept make sense.

03 Sketch that moment

Rough, fast, no erasing. Boxes, arrows, labels. Stick figures are fine.

04 Label everything

Name every component, annotate intent, explain placement.

05 Write one sentence

"This works because..." — say it without qualifying.

06 Show it to someone cold

Note exactly where they get confused — that's your next labelling job.

“

*Keep it to the **key screens** — one to three, not the whole flow. Sketch every screen and you've slipped into wireframing.*

THE DISCIPLINE THAT KEEPS IT A THINKING TOOL

Strong vs weak concept sketches

WEAK

- Polished — the time went into visual quality.
- Sketches the whole flow instead of the key screens.
- Components left unlabelled.
- No rationale — "it's obvious".
- Could belong to any product.

STRONG

- Rough — the time went into labelling and logic.
- Shows the one to three screens that make the concept legible.
- Every component named and annotated.
- Explicit "this works because..." statement.
- Only makes sense for this specific opportunity.

— YOU DON'T NEED A WORKSHOP

Five places a concept sketch can start

A "How might we" question

"How might we help users trust a new vendor?" → sketch two different trust signals.

A research insight

A user said "*I never know if it's fresh*" → sketch what proof-of-freshness looks like in the UI.

An analogy

"What if this worked like a playlist, not a search?" → sketch that model.

A constraint

"We can only change the checkout step" → sketch three ways that constraint becomes a feature.

A Crazy 8s panel

One of several starting points — not the only way in.

— ACTIVITY · ON-SITE · 10 MINUTES

Sketch one concept for one opportunity

Pick one opportunity you want to develop — then sketch a single concept that responds to it.

DO THIS

One labelled sketch

- Sketch the one concept that responds to your opportunity.
- Label every component.
- Write "this works because..."
- Keep it to a few key screens — rough, not polished.

SHARE BACK & DEBRIEF

Read it cold

- Can the person next to you read it without your help?
- Where does the sketch break down?
- What did labelling force you to decide?

The 30-second test

Show it cold to someone outside the session. Ask: *"What does this do? Who is it for?"*

Describes it in -30 seconds	Legible — ready to discuss and develop.
Gets the product, misses the interaction	Needs better component labels.
Confused about who it's for	The opportunity connection is missing from the sketch.
Needs you to explain it first	Needs more labelling — not more detail.

Say "this works because..." without qualifying

Watch for these four words — each one hides an assumption:

BUT

IF

AS LONG AS

ASSUMING

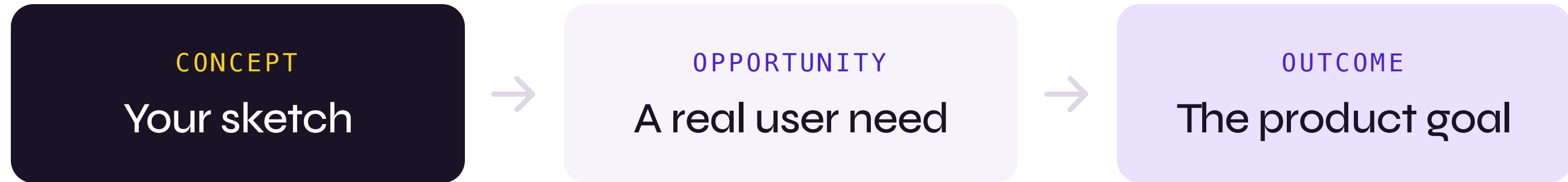
WEAK RATIONALE

- "...users will check the app each morning — *if* they have notifications on."
- "...people want to know where their food comes from — *assuming* they care."

STRONG RATIONALE

- "...it surfaces options at the moment of decision, not before it."
- "...it removes the research burden from the user and puts it on the platform."

Trace the concept back to the tree



Clean line to an opportunity

Grounded — ready to develop further.

Jumps straight to the outcome

You're solving a product goal, not a user need.

No clear line exists

The concept is floating — go back to the tree before building.

Ready to prototype when all four are true



Someone could **read it in 30 seconds** without your help.



The **"this works because..."** holds without qualifying.



You can name the **riskiest assumption** — and what you'd build to test it.



It **traces back** to a specific opportunity on your tree.

Doesn't pass? Sketch a version that resolves the failing check — **before you open Figma.**

Come with *one concept* ready to prototype

• BEFORE NEXT SESSION

01 Sketch your second concept

A *different approach* to the same opportunity — not a variation of the first.

02 Run the 30-second test on both

Show each to someone outside the project, no intro, and note exactly where they get confused.

03 Choose one concept to move forward with

Pick the direction you'll develop — that's where the prototype session begins.

The prototype session **starts from your chosen concept** — come ready to build.

THAT'S SKETCHING & VALIDATION

Thank you!

— *Winnie Nguyen*

NGUYENPHUCTUONGVAN@GMAIL.COM